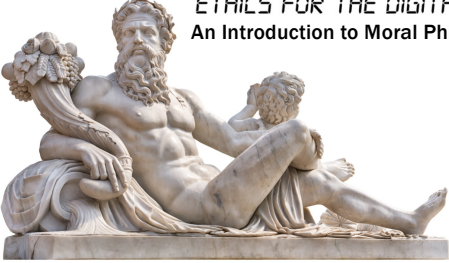


PHIL 1001
ETHICS FOR THE DIGITAL AGE
An Introduction to Moral Philosophy



Week 02, Lect. B
Troubles for the Divine Command Theory

UPHILSOC

UWA Undergraduate
Philosophy
Society

Who are we?
UPhilSoc is a student-led group focused on open discussion, critical thinking, and exploration of fundamental questions about existence, ethics, knowledge, and society.

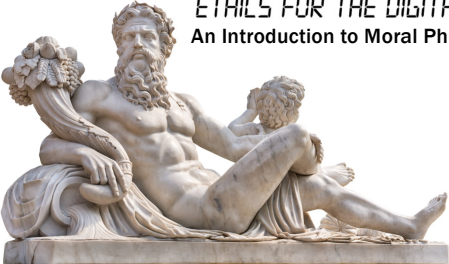
What do we do?
We provide supportive spaces for people to engage in, debate, and analyse complex ideas in a casual, inclusive setting.

Events to look forward to:
Weekly Tuesday Lunches (1-2pm)
Study Night in Week 11
Career Panel in Week 6, Semester 2

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UWA Undergraduate Philosophy Society



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Week 02, Lect. B
Troubles for the Divine Command Theory

Part I:
DCT (Recapped);
Its advantages

A statement of the Divine Command Theory:

DCT: An act, x, is morally right if and only if x does not violate any of God's commands.

Some potential positives for DCT:

- (a) Supports the **objectivity** of morality.
- (b) Potentially vindicates the belief that moral obligations imply **reasons for acting**.
- (c) Makes sense of the common thought that morality is closely **tied to religion** and/or God.

Part II: Several Quick Worries About DCT

Worry 1: Does the wrongness of (e.g.) torture for fun really hang on whether or not God exists?

Worry 2: Do we not count as **knowing** that torture for fun is wrong until we know that God exists, and know what God commands?

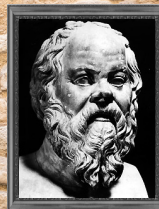
Worry 3: Even if God commands us (e.g.) not to lie, is God's command really **the reason** it is wrong to lie?

Part III: The Euthyphro Dilemma

Euthyphro's theory of **piety**:

"...what is dear to the gods is pious,
what is not [dear to the gods] is impious."

Socrates' question to Euthyphro:



"Is the pious loved by the gods
because it is pious,
or is it pious because
it is loved by the gods?"

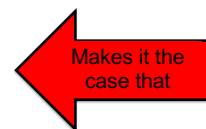
DCT asserts a necessary **correlation**
between facts of these two kinds:

Doing x is
Morally
Valuable
(obligatory)

God
commands
Doing x.

But what is **the direction of explanation**?

Doing x is
Morally
Valuable
(obligatory)

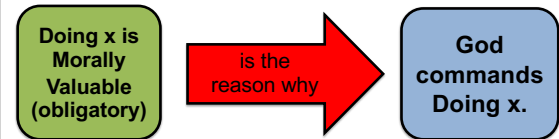


Makes it the
case that

God
commands
Doing x.

Are acts morally valuable¹ *or morally obligatory,
or ought to be done*
because they are commanded by God?

or



Does God command certain acts *because* they are morally valuable ?

i.e. ~~morally~~ good,
or ought to be done
or morally obligatory

(A) God commands us to do x **because** doing x is morally valuable.

OR

(B) Doing x is morally valuable. **because** God commands us to do x

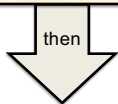


Horn A:
God commands x
because x is morally
obligatory
(or valuable)

(A) God commands us to do x **because** doing x is morally valuable.

OR

(B) Doing x is morally valuable. **because** God commands us to do x

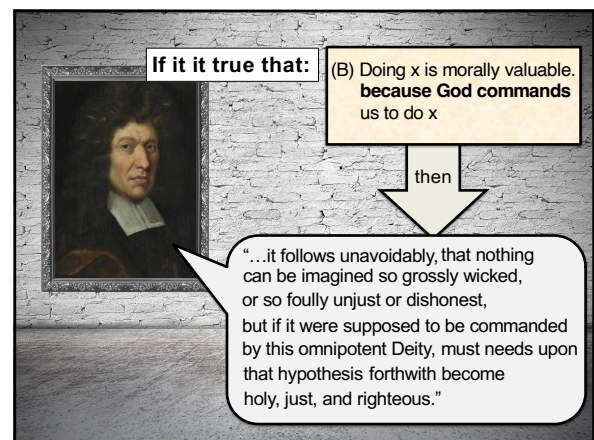
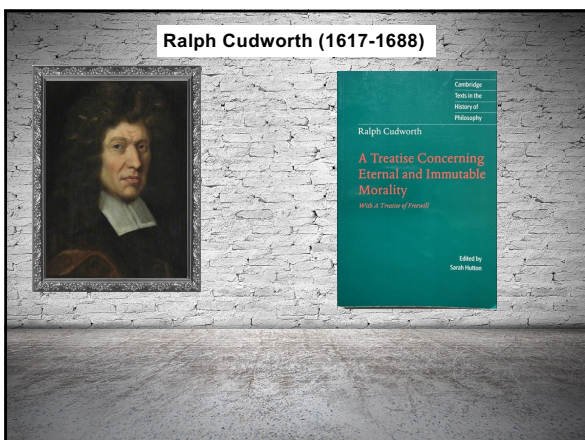
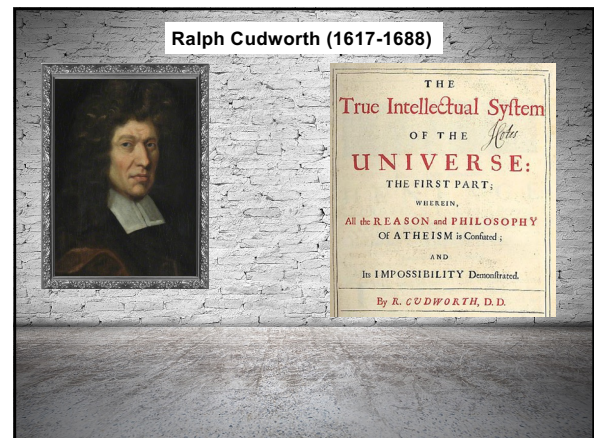
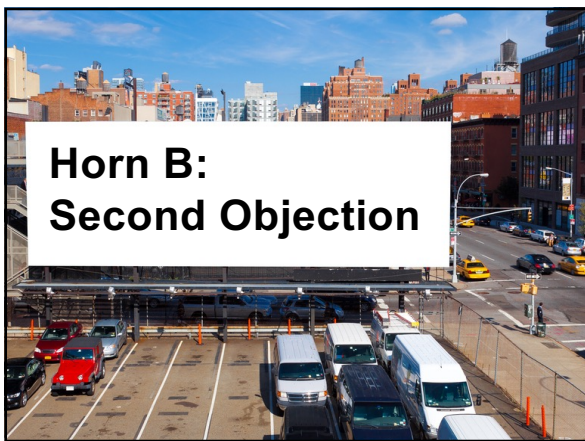
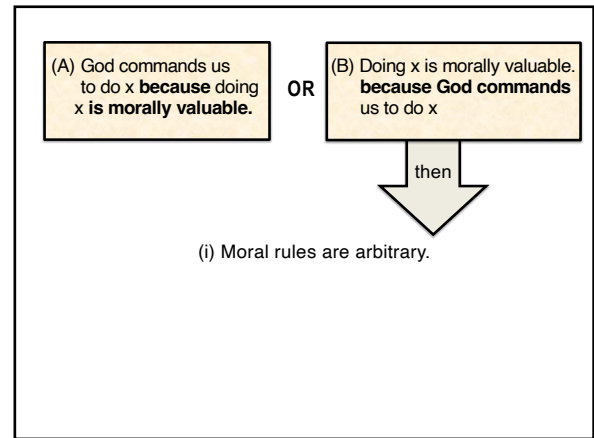
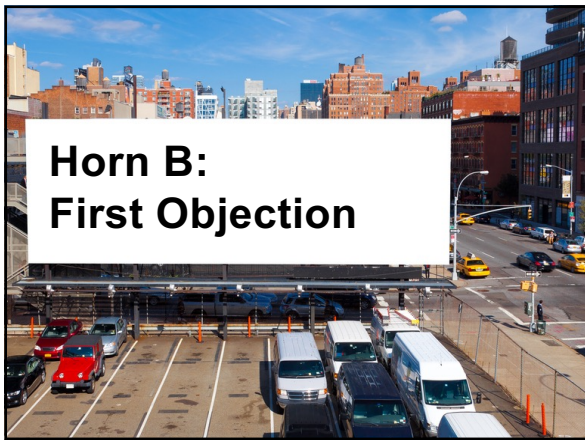


(a) God's **omnipotence** is undermined.

(b) DCT **loses explanatory power:**

Whatever *explains why* an act is valuable must be something **other than** God's commands.

Horn B:
x is morally obligatory
because God
commands x





The “Cruel Commands” Argument:

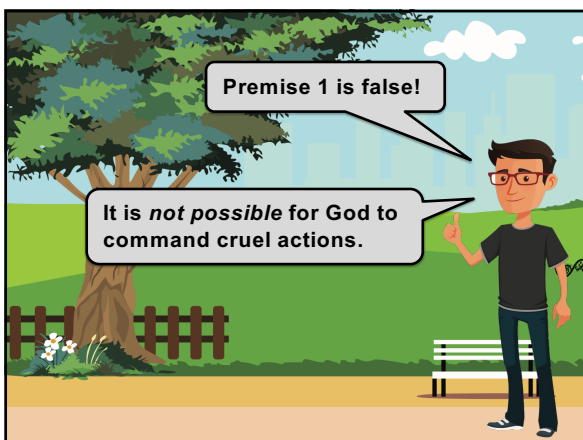
P1. It is possible for God to command humans to make each other suffer (for its own sake).

P2. If P1 and the Divine Command Theory were both true, then there could be a universe in which it is **morally wrong** to avoid making others suffer (for its own sake).

P3. **There cannot be** a universe in which it is **morally wrong** to avoid making others suffer (for its own sake).

C. The Divine Command Theory is not true.

**A Tempting Reply to
Cudworth’s
“Cruel Commands”
Objection**



**Three Problems
for The Divine
Command Theorist’s
Reply**

(a) But **why** couldn't God command cruelty?

(DC-Theorist can't just say: "because cruelty or suffering *is bad!*")

(b) The objection seems incompatible with God's having **free will**.

(c) For those D.C. Theorists belonging to the Abrahamic religious traditions:
(Scripture already portrays God as commanding actions that are similarly hard for many of us to accept as right.)

Some examples:

Deuteronomy 20: 10-18.

1 Samuel 15: 2-3.

Numbers 31: 17-18.*

* This command comes from Moses. It is unclear whether Moses is passing it on from God.

Horn B: Third Objection

Gottfried Wilhelm
von Leibniz
(1646 – 1716)

(1710)

Theodicy

G.W.
Leibniz

Gottfried Wilhelm
von Leibniz
(1646 – 1716)

"Those who believe that God established good and evil by an arbitrary decree are adopting that strange idea of mere indifference, and other absurdities still stranger."

They deprive God of the designation *Good*:
for what cause could one have to praise him for what he does, if in doing something quite different he would have done equally well?"

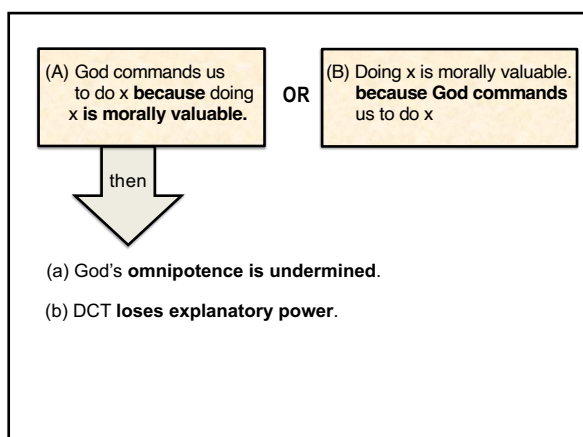
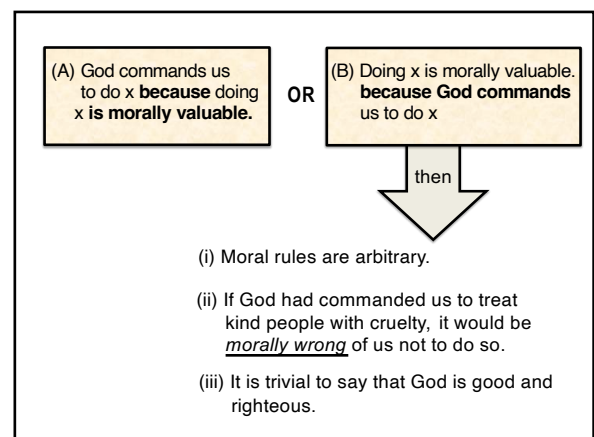
Gottfried Wilhelm
von Leibniz
(1646 – 1716)

For if justice was established arbitrarily, and without any cause, [that is] if God came upon it by a kind of hazard, as when one draws lots, [then] his goodness and wisdom are not manifested in it [i.e., in justice] and there is nothing at all to attach him to it [i.e. to justice].

An Analogy to Help Illuminate Leibniz's Point?

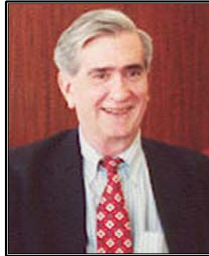


Summing up the Euthyphro Dilemma

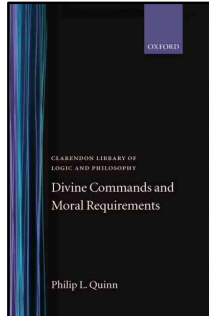


Postscript: Hope for Theologically-Based Moral Theories?

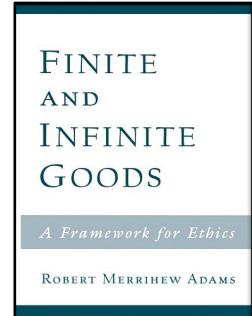
Philip L. Quinn (1978), *Divine Commands and Moral Requirements* (Oxford University Press).



(1940 - 2004)



Robert M. Adams (1999), *Finite and Infinite Goods* (Oxford University Press).



Linda Zagzebski (2004), *Divine Motivation Theory* (Cambridge University Press).

